

Cognition, Craft, and the Voice of the One-Pager

One Student's Explanation of the One-Pager and Five Examples

1. The One-Pager is a beautiful thing.

It allows me to listen to my voice, and it blocks out the noise of all of those other bully-voices. It lets me listen to *me* without the commotion of should, would, and could distracting my originality. At first the ambiguity of the one-pager terrified me. I wrote my first one on Anne Lamott's *Bird By Bird*. I loved the book; it captured the exact passion for writing that drove me to sign up for your class. I took nearly seven pages of notes on the novels' chapters, excited to eternalize favorite excerpts in my journal. *Bird By Bird* easily made my list of favorite books. Still, I felt nervous about the one-pager.

I intensely analyzed the syllabus's definition of the assignment, highlighting the part that said, "...pour what you are learning, thinking, or connecting because of your reading and/or particular experience." It seemed too simple. Anne Lamott made me want to write; she made me believe that I had an author in me. I wanted to write about that, about all the times that I chose to write above anything else, about the combinations of words I spewed onto paper just because they were there and I liked them, because maybe I needed them. So, I wanted to, and I did. I started that one-pager with a paragraph I wrote in the middle of the summer, an example of my use of writing as therapy. I found a connection between the comforts that *Bird By Bird* gave me in its advice, encouragement, and zest for writing and in my own love and application of the craft. I found my words without difficulty; I knew what I wanted to say, and I quickly filling the page with my language.

I felt uneasy, unsure that I had met expectations, but I turned the paper in anyway; I knew that there was no other way I wanted to write that one-pager. I went up to you after class and expressed my concern with the hope that I could lessen my confusion for the next one. You sent me an email a few days later entitled, "To Ease Your Mind," telling me that what I did worked. I was elated.

I appreciate the creative room with which they enable me, as well as the restriction they give in their one-page limit. I approached the one-pagers this semester like diary entries; I wrote what I needed to write. Lingered thoughts were at the heart of the writing; I did not force anything. The limit of the page's margins added to the coherency of my words because I knew that every space was valuable. Writing the one-pagers enhanced my understanding of the correlated readings and gave depth to my reactions.

I put several one-pagers in my anthology pages. I know that I will appreciate them in years to come not only as examples of my writing at nineteen years old, but also as evidence of what I learned in this course and what I thought about it...all in a page.

2. Poetry

The Journey

One day you finally knew
what you had to do, and began,
though the voices around you
kept shouting
their bad advice--
though the whole house

Deriving Writers

I was first inspired to start writing when I started reading good books. Jane Austen wrote in *Pride and Prejudice*, "A woman must have a through knowledge of...the modern languages to deserve the word... and to all this she must yet add something more substantial, in the improvement of her mind by extensive reading." Woman or man, boy or girl, it is a notable quality to be well read. Kittle says, "Good writing makes writers want to write" (74). Even Shakespeare based most of his work off of the literature he read; he is known for his eclecticism of combining classical stories with other materials to form new creations. He was impeccable at expanding and multiplying, characters and effects to surpass the classical models. For example Shakespeare's *Comedy of Errors* was based off Plautus' play *Menaechmi*. He used Plautus' idea of confusing identical twins, by expanding this notion to create two sets of twins adding a second twist to the plot. Current writers are still winding their plots around this idea such as the movie *Parent Trap* starring the Olson twins. Disney is famous for re-writing tales with new effects and spins.

When you read like a writer you discover how and why good authors are effective. They teach you how repeating ideas and images, short sentences, and punctuation can work to achieve beautiful meaning; you begin to get ideas, ideas that work and do good things. To become a writer Lorrie Moore says, "Try to be something, anything else....and fail miserably." Sometimes we all need a little critical disillusionment to inspire great writing; sometimes we need to laugh in syllables and count them and repeat them again and again. It's a crazy process of 'shitty first drafts', learning not to marry your own words because your most likely going to have to divorce them later, and shouting your voice all the way through so that just incase you forget to put your name on your paper everyone will know who's it is. Kittle understands this. She says, "If I listen well to my students, I know what to teach next" (86). Her teaching works because she gives comprehensible input, layering theory, as each child is ready for the next step.

Kittle teaches by example. She says, "My lessons are showing a way, not testing students on their ability to use each tool I provide" (81). I was very impressed with her decision to share Sherman Alexie's "Indian Education" with her class, simply because I have personally been inspired by much of his work. I applaud Kittle for bringing in and sharing current works, because this is a treat that I did not receive in high school. Yet Alexie, Jonathan Safran Foer, and Lorrie Moore have inspired most of my writing. It wasn't till college that I became an active reader and writer, an interpreter and a thinker. Consequently I know myself a little better now too. I only wish that I had a teacher like Kittle, who showed me the importance of being well read and accomplished in the languages. My teachers just told me and I believed them about as much as I believed my mom when she told me I'd turn into a noodle if I ate any more Mac and Cheese.



One-Pager: *Coming Through Slaughter*

Buddy Bolden Did Not Invent Jazz
Buddy Bolden Was Jazz

I went to Jazz Camp. I know the greats. Ella Fitzgerald. Louis Armstrong. Billie Holliday. But I never heard of this King Bolden fellow. Not until *Coming Through Slaughter*.

The casual interlace of the musical and the written. King Bolden entwined hymn and blues, church and gin joint, soul and sin. Served these genres "cooked up together" so it was impossible to separate out the Good Lord and the Devil. A fusion of the unfamiliar, an amalgamation of antithesis. Ragtime and Gospel and Folk and Blues and Marching Band and Soul all blended together. Jazz. Words and notes twist and writhe on the pages of this book, mingling and mixing, tumbling over each other and melding in a crazy crush of music and manuscript. Willy-nilly point-of-view flips, topsy-turvy dialogue bits. Poetry, prose, song, fact sheet, thrown in together to form a cluttered but coherent whole. Jazz.

I went to Jazz Camp. I know how to scat. But I never could completely wrap my mind around the concept. Somehow, I could never get right the mixture of pitch and timing and syllable and spin it into something wonderful.

The spontaneous spinning out of song and story. Improvisation the key to the King. The trick of the trumpet, the technique of the text. The name of the game. Jazz. Unvocal scat sent through a cornet, each sound a sudden surprise of thought, an instantaneous burst of inspiration. Bolden sucked song in and spat it out like breathing. No noticeable notion behind the notes, just feeling and fervor. This book scats its story, saying what it wants when, overlapping and underscoring itself in a wild frenzy. As the ear piques to follow the mad melody of the improvisator, so the eye flicks from page to page struggling to stay with the rapid-fire ramblings of the writer. Never knowing what's coming next. Jazz.

I went to Jazz Camp. I know the origins and I know the techniques. But this book showed me the culture surrounding the sound that I know so well.

The lifestyle of those who chose to live and love through this. *Jazz*. The whores and the pimps, the musicians and the dancers, the husbands and the wives, the women and the men caught up in a style that dictated them. The music flowed through the streets like gutter water, swirling at the feet of passers-by. This book shows what the music did to Bolden, how it came out of him and consumed him and became him. The cornet an extension of his arm. The music an extension of his soul. *Jazz*. Buddy Bolden did not invent Jazz. Buddy Bolden was Jazz.

I went to Jazz Camp. But I never understood Jazz till now.

Reading, Writing and Rising Up: Chapter 3

Writing the Word and the World

forgiving my teachers

my world was small and you
you made it smaller still.
introductions to nothing,
lectures covered familiar emptiness
I crossed my t's and dotted my i's
and that seemed to make you happy

someone asked me later what I thought
about something important and I
opened my mouth and was stunned
to find that you still where there.
you'd taken my tongue by hostage
and numbed my mind to the fight
of my spirit—my ideas. me.

it's clear to me now that you never
meant for this to happen.
you were *educating* me.
but I wish you'd noticed the damage,
the barren meaninglessness of my "intellect."
you told me I was smart. you told me
what I wanted to hear.

I wish you'd made me think
I wish you'd helped me grow
I wish you'd found some way to open up
the deepest thoughts and convictions
of your eager, waiting, wanting students.
you could have exposed the world
for what it is—you could have made us all
made sense of it.

it's too late for that now. all that's left
to do is forget and refresh and make vows
never again to neglect.

his is tough
in sorry
for had to
write this

Teachers have the unique opportunity of
presence in their students' lives. Five days a week from
morning through afternoon, young people are asked to
be students, and teachers to teach. But it was my grade
school experience that this "opportunity" was more of a
requirement. Most students seem to feel this way at
least every once in a while throughout their schooling.
But so much gets missed when students and teachers
turn to apathy. In these classrooms, teachers crack open
books and students scribble down notes for upcoming
tests, mindlessly experiencing "education."

In her book, Linda Christensen writes,
"Sometimes I remind myself that I'm an English teacher
and I question whether I'm straying too far afield. I
know my pasture is broader than nouns and verbs,
stories, poems and essays. Where does the world begin
that is within my terrain?" (Christensen 62). It's an
interesting question. As a future teacher, I'm beginning
to chew on it myself. So few teachers really use the
opportunity to move mere curriculum towards the active
learning realm—and even fewer allow their classrooms
to search for social justice through their reading of texts
and their own writing. It is my hope to become the sort
of teacher whose goal is to leave an impression on my
students' minds and hearts. I want to encourage their
own discovery of their unique worldviews through the
subject matter of my classroom.

But there are complications that arise when
teachers extend beyond their role of knowledge-bearer
and sage. When we engage the world in a conversation
of reading and writing, we might hear some things that
trouble us. Indeed, we may also discover that we

ourselves have things to say that might upset what we've always known. It's risky business, but it is
my belief that it is only when we *risk* that we gain. Christensen shares her own experience with this
risk and where the problems arise. "While kids learned to question, while they broke down their
senses of isolation and alienation, while they pushed toward a greater knowledge of how this society
functions," Christensen explains, "they were moved less often to hope and action and more often to
awareness and despair than I felt comfortable with" (62).

We live in a troubled world with complicated problems that demand a discussion. Certainly,
we shouldn't overlook the darkness of the world and thereby signal our ignorance of issues and
unwillingness to seek change. But just as one of Christensen's students commented, "You need to
include some more positive aspects. We can't live in a world where it's all negative. I became
overwhelmed and angry. I felt like I couldn't take it" (62). With this in mind, I desire to center my
future in teaching around both truth (even in all its ugliness) in the presence of love, hopefully
instilling within my students a sense of balance in perspective—both wisdom *and* hope.

and maybe with
a mission of action, too

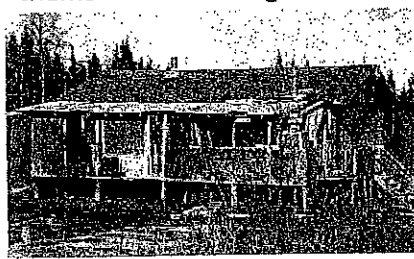
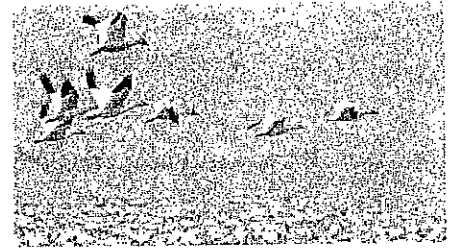
Lives on the Boundary (ch. 5 and 6)

Cause and Effect: Migration

TSJ That last it is where you really get into a complicated issue that you are puzzled by. I'd like to have seen you explore that.

Rose's style throughout chapter 5 really changes my opinion on *Lives on the Boundary*. Whereas the beginning starts off with a similar style as the other pages we have read thus far, as I read chapter 5 I became intrigued. If we're being honest, I have not particularly enjoyed the excerpts we have read by Rose so far. I have felt as if his writing has been merely dry summary but my opinion has further developed and changed for the better after reading chapters 5 and 6.

Throughout chapter 5, Rose shares a story in which ~~a student teacher~~ ^{he begins an} intern period at a school and adjusts to the vastly different culture ~~he~~ is used to. Some of the details he includes to preface the story include the idea that residents of "Maraville hold onto the hope of moving into communities to the east" (87). I find this detail relatable because I too come from a town in which everyone seeks to move away after graduation. I think this idea of moving away generates from residents who do not particularly like their place of residency, and desire to move elsewhere they believe they will enjoy more. The reality of this concept is that most of the citizens from my town do not move away after high school. They reside in the same little town for the entirety of their lives but complain throughout their time there. This has never made sense to me and I am not sure if the residents of Maraville are the same way but this connection was one I closely related with.



Another idea I enjoyed was the fact that the school "required its interns to familiarize themselves with neighborhoods in which they would work" (88) in order to get to know the students. This is a brilliant idea that more schools should incorporate. I think if more schools implemented this method, the school would become much more cohesive as a result of a better overall understanding of where the students come from. Going along with knowing where students come from, teachers would be able to learn that students come from "the house-trailer boarded up and weeds were growing high around cracked concrete slabs" (90). It's important to know these details so that teachers are prepared to communicate appropriately with a student and their family.

Rose delves into the chapter and discusses the culture of the school and describes the tasks of the respected student teacher. ~~The student teacher~~ ^{he} is assigned a group of students with poor reading skills and creates lessons to help improve their skills. ~~The student teacher~~ ^{Rose} reflects on each child's skills and abilities in comparison to their test scores. A specific quote referenced standardized tests, "it only measures how well they want to play the game" (98). ~~The student teacher~~ ^{he} found that it was common for ~~the~~ students to be capable of writing, 1-2 grades below level, but still capable of writing to be tested as 'retarded' because their scores were so low. This is unacceptable to me and I wish there was more explanation as to why this occurs.

Teaching is a romance and building relationships with students is so important. Most of my most influential teachers are ones I have built relationships with.

Students are boarded and labeled

I'd like to have seen you explore this point